Alexander's invasion is not mentioned directly in Indian texts but the Macedonians have left us detailed accounts of their adventures. [16] Some of them includes fantastical tales about giant ants that were used to dig for gold. However, for the most part, their observations were accurate. Nearchus, Alexander's admiral, tells us that Indians wore clothes made from white cotton. The lower garment reached below the knee, halfway to the ankles. The upper garment was thrown over the shoulder and a turban was worn on the head. Nearchus was describing the dhoti and angavastra—clothes that have been worn since Vedic times and continue to be worn even today. He goes on to say that wealthy Indians wore ivory earrings and used parasols against the sun. They also wore leather sandals with elaborate trimmings and thick soles to make themselves look taller!

Although Alexander's invasion did not make much of a dent in the Indian heartland, it did trigger a chain of events that led to the founding of India's first great empire, that of the Mauryas. The empire was created by two extraordinary characters: Chanakya (also called Kautilya [17] ) and his pupil Chandragupta Maurya. The Persian, Chinese and Macedonian Greek empires were created by princes and warriors. In contrast, Chanakya was a professor of Political Economy in Taxila. When Alexander entered into an alliance with the king of Taxila, the Brahmins of the city opposed this. Plutarch tells us that Alexander had several of them hanged to death. [18]

According to legend, Chanakya then travelled east to Pataliputra (modern Patna), capital of the powerful kingdom of Magadh to ask for help against the Greeks. However, he was insulted and thrown out by the king of the Nanda dynasty. Chanakya decided to return to Taxila to plot his revenge. On the way he met a boy called Chandragupta Maurya. There are some interesting tales—impossible to verify—about how they met. Chanakya took the boy back with him and began to train him for future kingship. He also wrote the *Arthashastra* (Treatise on Prosperity), a detailed manual on how to run the future empire.

When Alexander died, there was a power vacuum in northwest India. Chanakya and his protégé used the opportunity to put together a band of